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Quoting Mieke Bal's Navel: Contemporary Theory, Preposterous Religion

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Bennett-Carpenter - Quoting Mieke Bal's Navel - JCRT 4.1
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I

Art and literary theorist Mieke Bal may be read in terms of a philosophy or theory of religion in a genealogy that begins with Kierkegaard, runs through Nietzsche and Heidegger and concludes in the vicinity of Merleau-Ponty, Foucault, and Derrida.¹ With Kierkegaard and Nietzsche, hers is a post-Christendom, post-Christian theory of religion that could be described at the outset as 'preposterous.' With Nietzsche and Heidegger, her critical and interpretive strategies *circulate*, not to attempt a circumvention of meaning, but to negotiate the limits of significant horizons. With Heidegger and Merleau-Ponty, she follows a *bodied* phenomenology that can never extricate itself from the world and earth. With Derrida and Foucault, she is both deconstructive and post-structuralist as she moves amongst the play of signs and the rhetoric of resistance. Finally, she stands as an alternative to Baudrillard in a world of theory after Foucault and Derrida or, at least, in the midst of their traces.

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Notes

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¹At least it is in this 'tradition' that I have sought to represent her in the following project. And perhaps in this case Kant stands as a matrix for the whole genealogy. Of course it is also possible to trace other genealogies; for example in a semiotic 'tradition' of Saussure and Barthes, along with Culler and Eco. This is not to mention narratological, psychoanalytic, or feminist 'traditions' to which she is indebted as well, nor even, in a certain sense, her close position to art historical figures like Duchamp, which I mention later. Certainly one of Bal's strengths is her draw upon various 'traditions' or disciplines: she's a true interdisciplinarian. I try here to orient the reader by way of one genealogy to begin with and to touch on the various others as the article proceeds.

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